

Global Luxury Goods

Global Luxury Goods: The Future of Small Brands



Luca Solca
+41 582 723 126
luca.solca@bernsteinsg.com



Maria Meita
+44 20 7170 0540
maria.meita@bernsteinsg.com



Eric Chen, CFA
+852 2123 2628
eric.chen@bernsteinsg.com



Yi-Peng Khoo, CFA
+44 20 7676 6822
yi-peng.khoo@bernsteinsg.com

Specialist Sales



Alix Turner
+44 20 7762 4044
alix.turner@bernsteinsg.com

It is time to put small luxury brands under the spotlight, following up on our work on mega-brands ([The Future of Mega-Brands](#), 2013) and trailing “tail” brands ([How Long Is Your Tail?](#) 2009, [Global Luxury Goods: How Long is your Tail? Reloaded](#) 2020).

A more stable consumer base is producing a better environment for smaller brands.

The fixed cost nature of the industry and new consumers driving most of the growth - all wanting to buy the “luxury essentials” - have favoured mega-brands in the past 30 years. The fixed cost structure of the industry doesn’t change. But a more established consumer base needing something new to part with their money provides a more favourable environment for smaller brands (see [Weekend Consumer Blast: The Luxury Mega-Brand Bathtub – Redux](#)).

A CLEARER SMALL LUXURY BRANDS LANDSCAPE IS EMERGING

We see four major groups:

High-end specialists

These brands operate at the highest price points and have virtually nothing for aspirational consumers in their assortment. They appear to be best positioned to capture the richest consumers turning to mega-brand alternatives and have been doing so for at least 15 years. Given their scale disadvantage, they are likely to continue to produce substandard retail space productivity, EBIT%, and ROIC. Publicly traded examples of this group are **Zegna**, **Brunello Cucinelli**, **Loro Piana**. Privately held companies include **Kiton**, **Stefano Ricci**.

Category specialists

These brands stand out as recognised specialists in their category, while occupying the upper end of the pricing pyramid within the broader fashion and leather goods space. We find a diverse array of players in this cohort, as a function of their idiosyncratic product origin - e.g.

- **Moncler** in down jackets
- **Burberry** in trench coats
- **Bottega Veneta** in handbags
- **Tod's** and **Salvatore Ferragamo** in footwear

Most of these brands would like to be bigger and eventually become mega-brands. So they are trying to expand into adjacent product categories. This development path is both appropriate and frustrating: 1) Appeal outside of the core category would sustain growth (as it has for mega-brands before them: see Hermès or Chanel as examples); 2) Yet, moving into spaces occupied by mega-brands and other specialists often results in profit dilution.

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Flankers

These brands squarely operate in the same price range and multi-category space that mega-brands occupy. In most cases, they are not differentiated enough to stand out because of either product or price specialisation. They are therefore destined to suffer most of the time. Their strategic role within larger groups is to serve as “flankers”: occupying retail space around mega-brands to keep competitor mega-brands at a distance, as well as sometimes overlapping in their positioning with competitor mega-brands to try and steal some of the tailwind behind them. In this group we have the “tail” we have written about: **Fendi, Celine, Loewe, Kenzo, Balenciaga, Alexander McQueen, Miu Miu**, etc.

Meteors

Some flankers sometimes hit gold, manage to stand out and get more prominent than their meagre marketing budgets would normally allow and experience a significant growth spurt - only to most often fade behind the horizon as they become yesterday's stories. The break typically comes from a hero product (think Celine under Phoebe Philo); an aesthetic and marketing statement (think Celine under Hedi Slimane or the most recent Miu Miu); a home run success in a product category (think Alexander McQueen and sneakers); or a combination of several of these elements (think Balenciaga under Demna Gvasalia). The problem with these successes is that they most often cannot sustain. We have yet to see a meteor break into mega-brand territory. While we have seen many disappear back into oblivion.

A FEW STRATEGIC IMPLICATIONS EMERGE FROM OUR PROPOSED BRAND TAXONOMY:

Shareholder value creation through small brands is structurally difficult, even in the current more favourable consumer environment. Small players are bound to suffer from structurally lower ROIC, as they stand at a scale disadvantage.

- **Investors would need to benefit from small brands continuing to sustain growth, ideally above sector average.** This is currently possible for high-end specialists like BC and Zegna; debatable for category specialists like Moncler; improbable for most flankers and meteors over the medium to long-term.
- **Alternatively, investors would need to benefit from catching a flanker just before it turns into a meteor.** Which would call for a momentum investment approach with near-perfect timing.

Luxury conglomerates without a mega-brand would have little justification to own flankers within the broader luxury fashion and leather goods market. Richemont stands out in this respect, as owning brands like Chloe, Dunhill, Gianvito Rossi or Serapian seems - at best - only responding to a will to learn (at a cost) about soft luxury. But without any prospect of producing profit performance and capital returns anywhere near those of the hard luxury core business. More simply said: if you don't have a mega-brand, your small brands cannot be flankers, hence they serve very little constructive purpose.

Even major luxury conglomerates with deep pockets (courtesy of their mega-brands) benefit from pruning their flankers when markets are tough. The recent examples of Richemont divesting Baume & Mercier and LVMH selling Marc Jacobs are a case in point. Of course, selling loss making businesses is very difficult, which limits Kering's options when dealing with Alexander McQueen at the moment.

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

Ticker	Rating	4 Jun 2026		Price Target	TTM Rel. Perf.	Adjusted EPS				Adjusted P/E (x)		
		Cur	Closing Price			Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
BIRK (Birkenstock)	M	USD	42.99	50.00	(50.0)%	EUR	1.85	2.01	2.49	20.0	18.4	14.9
BC.IM (Brunello Cucinelli)	O	EUR	83.10	108.00	(35.0)%	EUR	1.99	2.26	2.65	41.8	36.8	31.3
BRBY.LN (Burberry)	O	GBp	1,112.00	1,300.00	(11.4)%	GBP	0.24	0.39	0.55	45.5	28.6	20.3
CFR.SW (Richemont)	O	CHF	164.55	200.00	(6.5)%	EUR	5.96	6.89	7.71	30.1	26.0	23.3
ZGN	O	USD	14.92	14.00	63.6%	EUR	0.45	0.42	0.60	28.4	30.4	21.3
RMS.FP (Hermès)	O	EUR	1,582.50	2,150.00	(46.8)%	EUR	43.12	44.33	52.47	36.7	35.7	30.2
KER.FP (Kering)	M	EUR	249.05	220.00	28.9%	EUR	4.35	6.66	10.04	57.2	37.4	24.8
MC.FP (LVMH)	O	EUR	474.10	600.00	(13.8)%	EUR	22.73	22.22	26.71	20.9	21.3	17.7
MONC.IM (Moncler)	M	EUR	53.50	57.50	(15.9)%	EUR	2.31	2.44	2.64	23.2	21.9	20.3
1913.HK (Prada SpA)	O	HKD	37.00	50.00	(72.9)%	EUR	0.33	0.32	0.36	12.2	12.9	11.4
SFER.IM (Ferragamo)	O	EUR	9.31	8.80	52.8%	EUR	(0.30)	0.04	0.15	(31.5)	247.9	63.4
UHR.SW (Swatch)	O	CHF	209.30	180.00	35.3%	CHF	0.03	4.32	8.16	N/M	48.4	25.6
SPX			7,584.31									
EDME			1,548.21									
EMLSF			6,043.37									
ASIAX			2,024.37									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

BRBY.LN, CFR.SW base year is 2026;

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

The trajectory of a recovery in global luxury demand remains uncertain. We find two sources of volatility at play: a) underlying demand gyrations, as consumers navigate a fragile macro-economic environment and a tenser and tenser geopolitical environment; and b) short-term investors playing the sector long and short, amplifying upswings and downswings beyond natural news flow. In this context of heightened uncertainty, we would take a more defensive posture with a core exposure to plain vanilla:

1) We would prefer high-quality names “at fair value”... **Richemont** is our top preference due to strong jewellery momentum and leadership, with **Brunello Cucinelli** also favored for their quality and potential mean reversion. It is difficult to be positive on **Hermès** in the short-term, but one weak quarter can be forgiven by the market, if they return to high single digit growth ([Hermès: Valuations already discount a 'Ferrari reset'](#)).

2) ...as well as the self-help stories with more promising trajectories. **LVMH** sits between high quality and self-help. Lingering concerns around the W&S turnaround and the Arnault family's ‘Darwinian’ succession process are counter-balanced by Dior's revival, cost efficiencies, and Louis Vuitton's strength; Turnaround at **Burberry** is well on track. One-year anniversary of the Burberry Forward strategy has paid off, in the form of improved brand momentum and stronger full-price sell-through. With a solid foundation in place, the next leg of the turnaround will see focus shifting to driving store productivity, by capitalizing on the extended momentum in other categories from the core outerwear & scarf; **Ferragamo** is at the earlier stage of and trading at the lower end of the trading range. Recent conversation with management suggests a possible turnaround in the making, as a team of “old hands” are tackling key issues around the brand, assortment and retail store network.

DETAILS

A more stable consumer base is producing a better environment for smaller brands. The fixed cost nature of the industry and new consumers driving most of the growth - all wanting to buy the “luxury essentials” - have favoured mega-brands in the past 30 years. The fixed cost structure of the industry doesn't change. But a more established consumer base needing something new to part with their money provides a more favourable environment for smaller brands (see [Weekend Consumer Blast: The Luxury Mega-Brand Bathtub – Redux](#)).

A CLEARER SMALL LUXURY BRANDS LANDSCAPE IS EMERGING

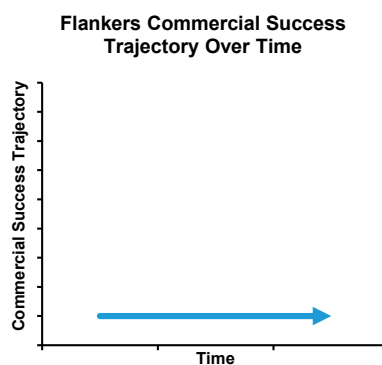
We see four major groups:

EXHIBIT 1: **Conceptual charts for (category and high-end) Specialists**



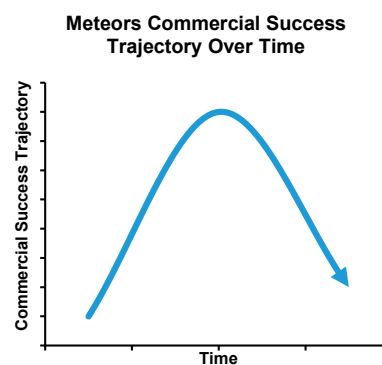
Source: Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 2: **Conceptual charts for Flankers**



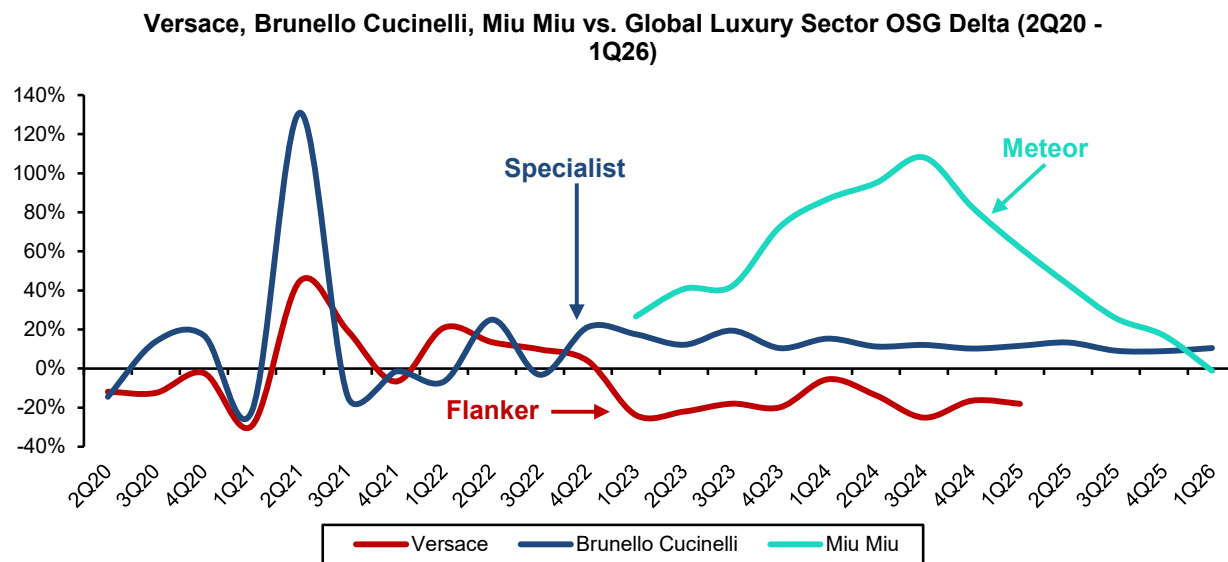
Source: Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 3: **Conceptual charts for Meteors**



Source: Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 4: **Examples of High-end Specialist, Flanker and Meteor**



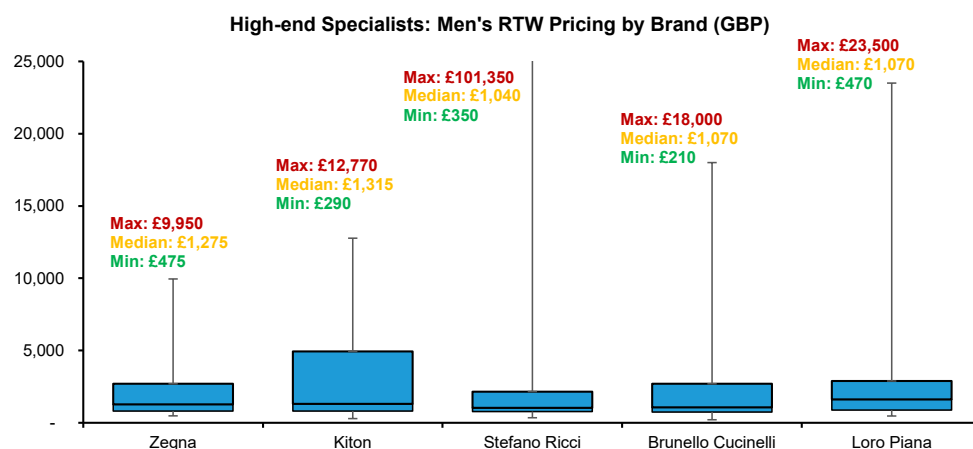
Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

High-end specialists

These brands operate at the highest price points and have virtually nothing for aspirational consumers in their assortment. They appear to best positioned to capture the richest consumers turning to mega-brand alternative and have been doing so for at least 15 years. Given their scale disadvantage, they are likely to continue to produce substandard retail space

productivity, EBIT%, and ROIC. Publicly traded examples of this group are **Zegna**, **Brunello Cucinelli**, **Loro Piana**. Privately held companies include **Kiton**, **Stefano Ricci**.

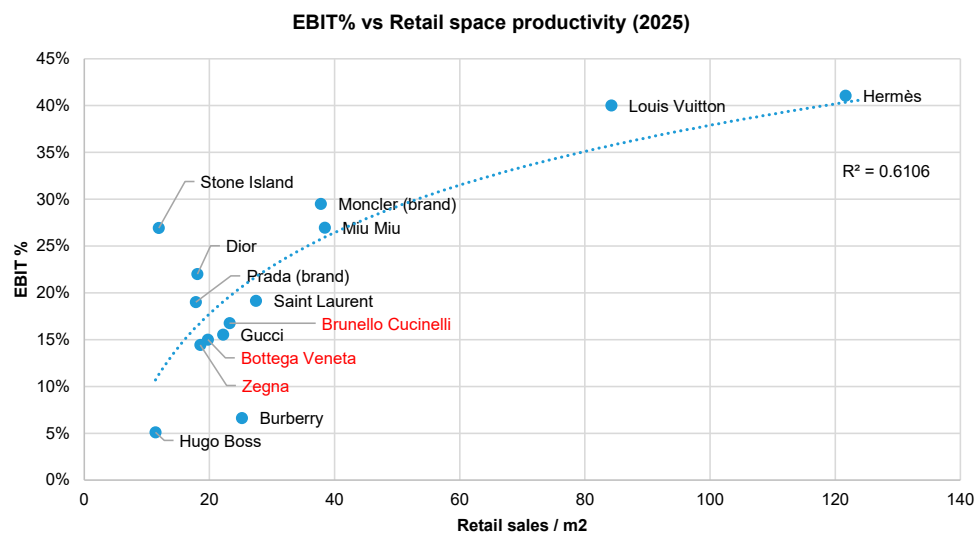
EXHIBIT 5: The high-end specialists, operating at the highest price points, are best positioned to capture the richest consumers turning to mega-brand alternative



Only menswear RTW products are compared. Prices are obtained from UK brand.com, except Kiton and Stefano Ricci, where prices are only listed in EUR and converted to GBP at EURGBP spot rate

Source: brand.com

EXHIBIT 6: Given their scale disadvantage, high-end specialists are likely to continue to produce substandard retail space productivity, EBIT%, and ROIC



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

Category specialists

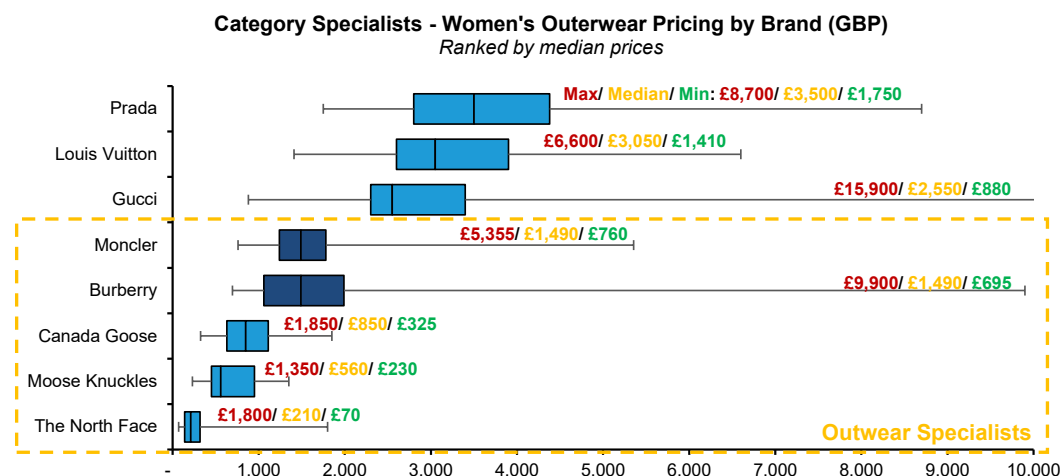
These brands stand out as recognised specialists in their category, while occupying the upper end of the pricing pyramid within the broader fashion and leather goods space. We find a diverse array of players in this cohort, as a function of their idiosyncratic product origin - e.g.

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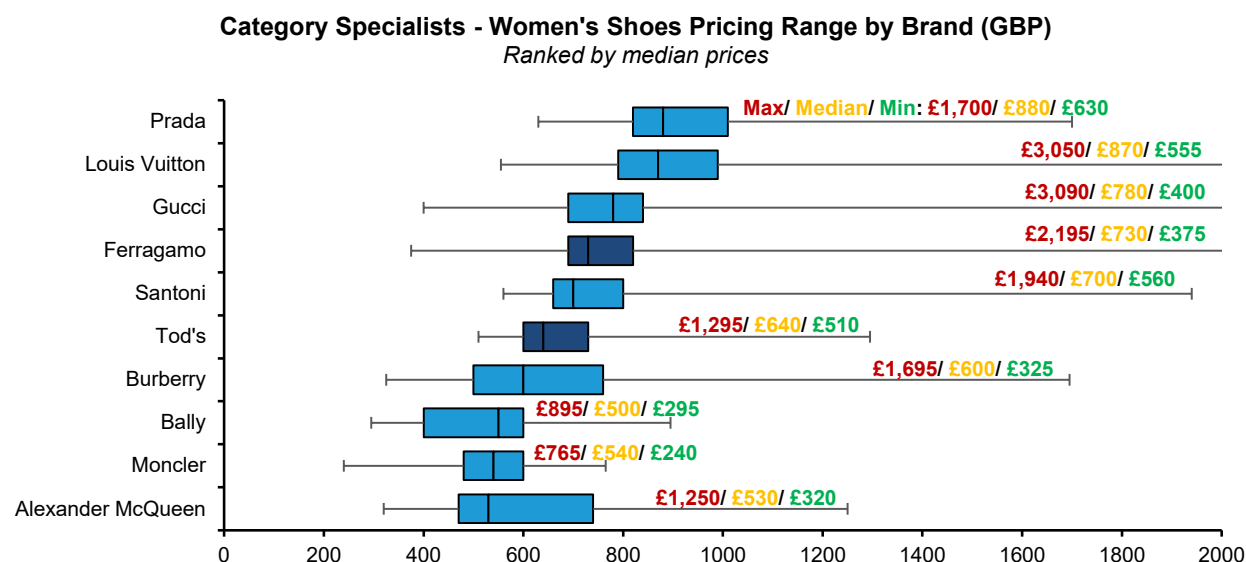
Most of these brands would like to be bigger and eventually become mega-brands. So they are trying to expand into adjacent product categories. This development path is both appropriate and frustrating: 1) Appeal outside of the core category would sustain growth (as it has for mega-brands before them: see Hermès or Chanel as examples); 2) Yet, moving into spaces occupied by mega-brands and other specialists often results in profit dilution.

EXHIBIT 7: **Moncler (down jackets) and Burberry (trench coats) are specialist outerwear brands that command the highest pricing within their respective peer groups, though they remain priced below luxury mega-brands**



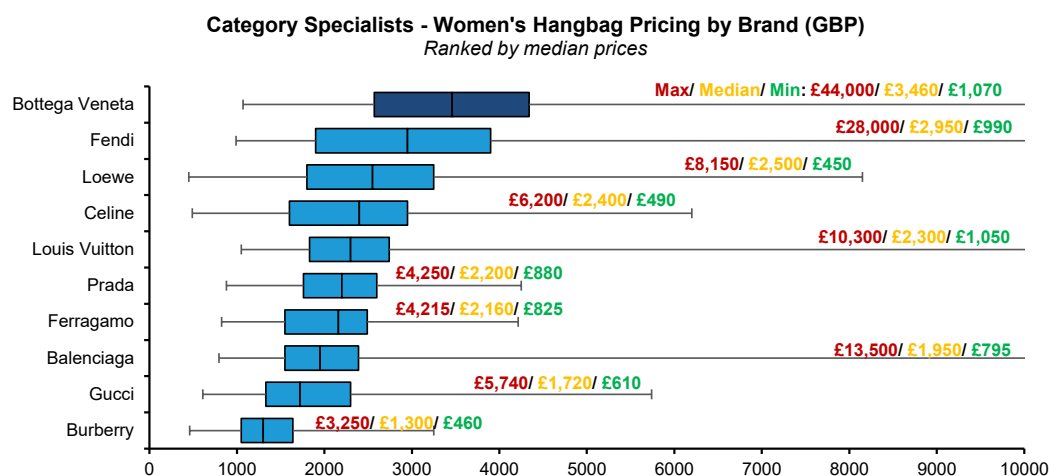
All data are collected from the UK brand.com.
Source: brand.com, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 8: **A similar dynamic applies to Tod's and Ferragamo, which lead pricing among footwear peers but still lag behind luxury mega-brands**



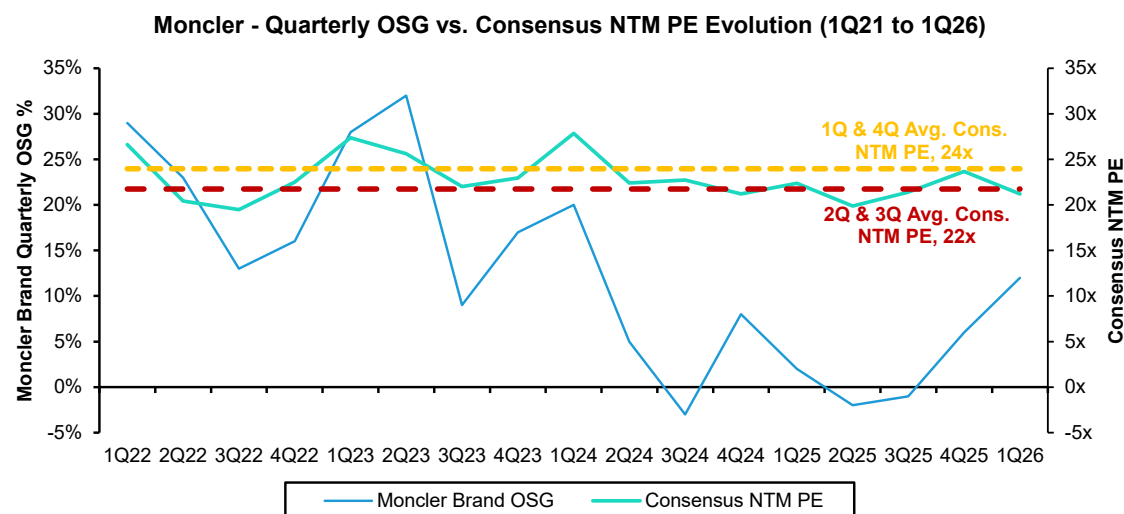
All data are collected from the UK brand.com. Thigh-high boots are excluded.
Source: brand.com, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 9: Bottega Veneta's women's handbags are positioned at the very top of the pricing spectrum, leading across minimum, median, and maximum price points



All data are collected from the UK brand.com. Pouches and pouchettes are excluded.
Source: brand.com, Bernstein analysis

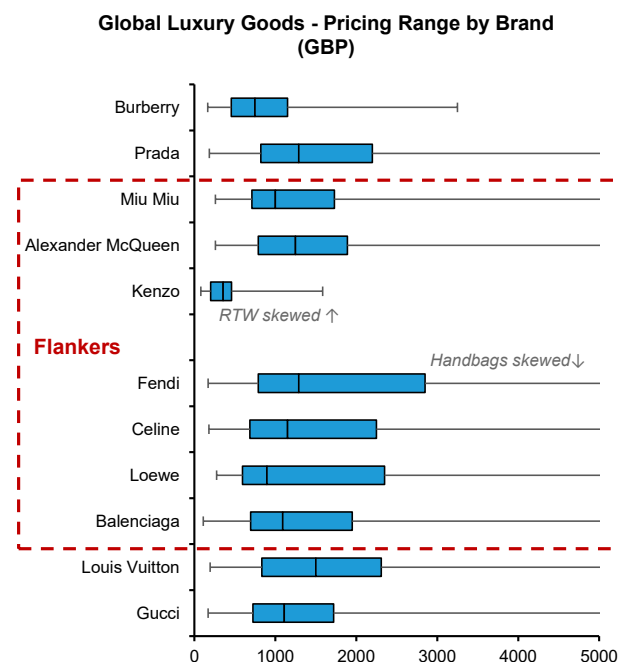
EXHIBIT 10: Moncler's OSG, along with its consensus NTM P/E multiple, exhibits a clear seasonal pattern—declining into the summer months and rebounding in winter—despite the company's ongoing efforts to expand its summerwear offering



Source: Company reports, Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

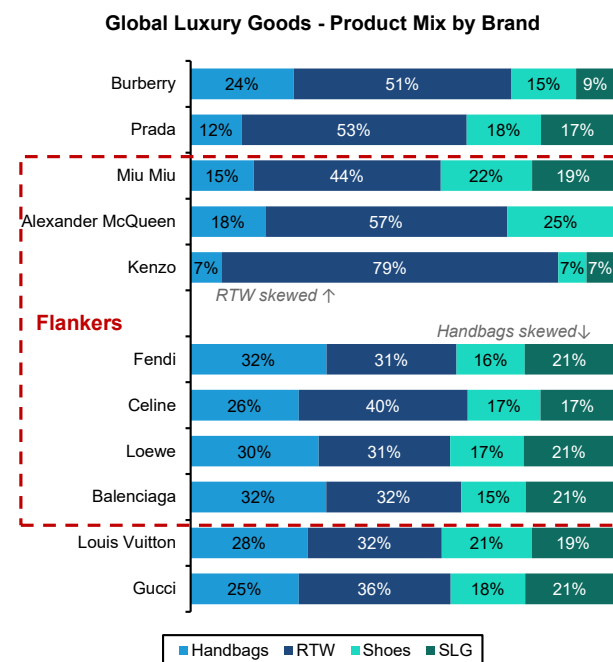
Flankers

These brands squarely operate in the same price range and multi-category space that mega-brands occupy. In most cases, they are not differentiated enough to stand out because of either product or price specialisation. They are therefore destined to suffer most of the time. Their strategic role within larger groups is to serve as “flankers”: occupying retail space around mega-brands to keep competitor mega-brands at a distance, as well as sometimes overlapping in their positioning with competitor mega-brands to try and steal some of the tailwind behind them. In this group we have the “tail” we have written about: **Fendi, Celine, Loewe, Kenzo, Balenciaga, Alexander McQueen, Miu Miu**, etc.

EXHIBIT 11: **The flankers squarely operate in the same price range...**

All data are collected from the UK brand.com. Whiskers represent the minimum and maximum prices, while the bottom, midpoint and top of the box are 1st quartile, median and 3rd quartile prices, across handbags, RTW, shoes and small leather goods

Source: brand.com, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 12: **...and multi-category space that mega-brands occupy**

All data are collected from the UK brand.com. We've excluded accessories/ jewellery as a category, as the definition varies across brands

Source: brand.com, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 13: **Their strategic role within larger groups is to serve as “flankers”: occupying retail space around mega-brands to keep competitor mega-brands at a distance**

Taikoo Li Qiantan, Shanghai - Level 1 Store Locations by Brand

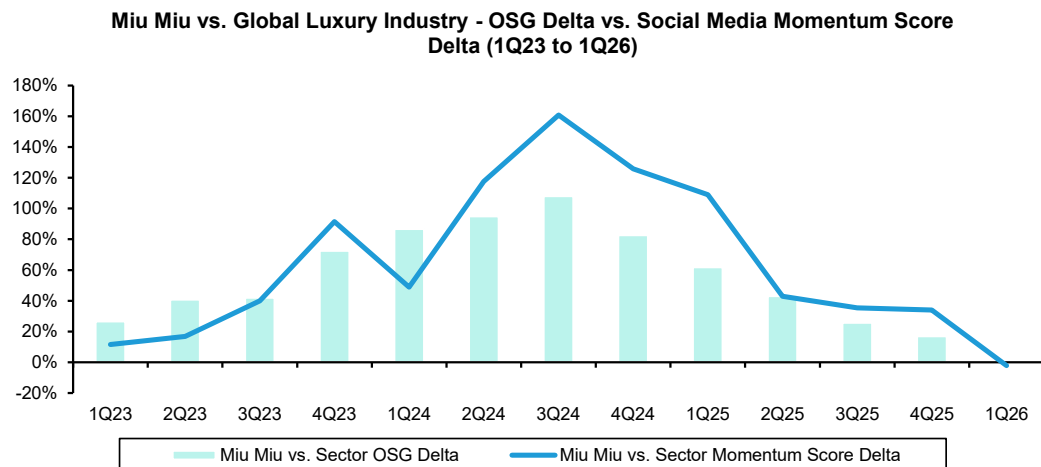


Source: Company website, RED, Bernstein analysis

Meteors

Some flankers sometimes hit gold, manage to stand out and get more prominent than their meagre marketing budgets would normally allow and experience a significant growth spurt - only to most often fade behind the horizon as they become yesterday's stories. The break typically comes from a hero product (think Celine under Phoebe Philo); an aesthetic and marketing statement (think Celine under Hedi Slimane or the most recent Miu Miu); a home run success in a product category (think Alexander McQueen and sneakers); or a combination of several of these elements (think Balenciaga under Demna Gvasalia). The problem with these successes is that they most often cannot sustain. We have yet to see a meteor break into mega-brand territory. While we have seen many disappear back into oblivion.

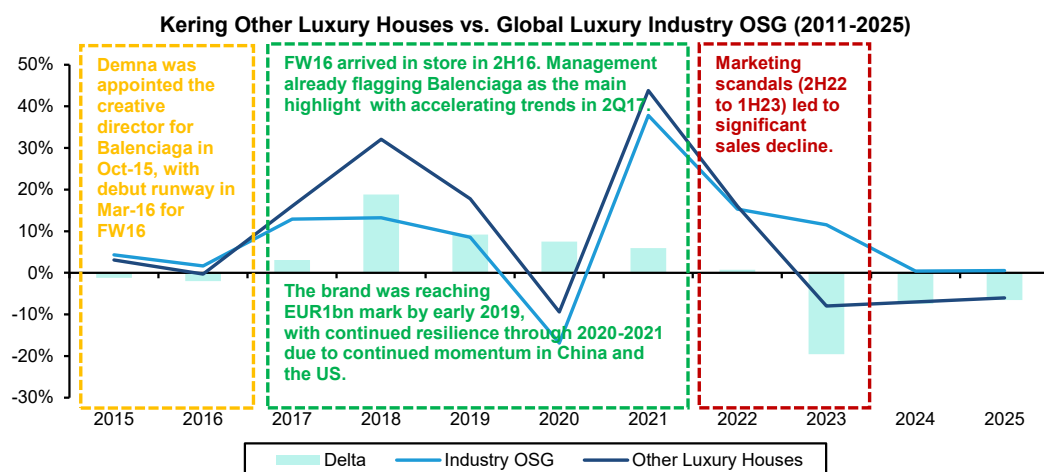
EXHIBIT 14: Miu Miu recently struck a chord with its distinctive aesthetic positioning; however, the subsequent growth surge appears to have tapered off alongside a moderation in brand momentum



China and West social media momentum scores are averaged for each brand (excluding Ralph Lauren)

Source: Company reports, Bernstein estimates and analysis

EXHIBIT 15: Balenciaga under Demna is another illustrative example: the brand significantly outperformed the sector between 2017 and 2021 as it capitalised on the broader shift toward streetwear. However, this momentum subsequently reversed, with performance deteriorating following brand marketing controversies and as its aesthetic fell out of favour



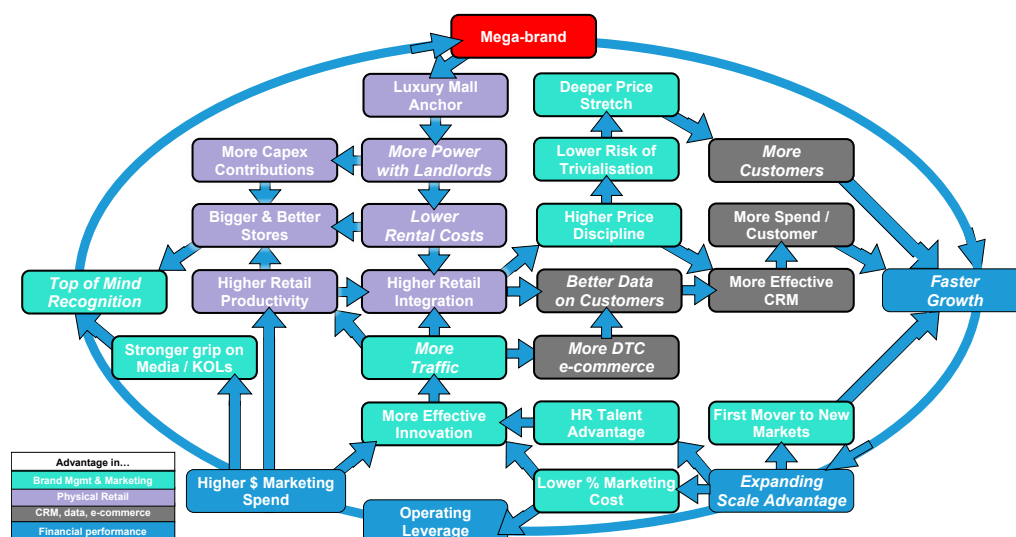
Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

A FEW STRATEGIC IMPLICATIONS EMERGE FROM OUR PROPOSED BRAND TAXONOMY:

Shareholder value creation through small brands is structurally difficult, even in the current more favourable consumer environment. Small players are bound to suffer from structurally lower ROIC, as they stand at a scale disadvantage.

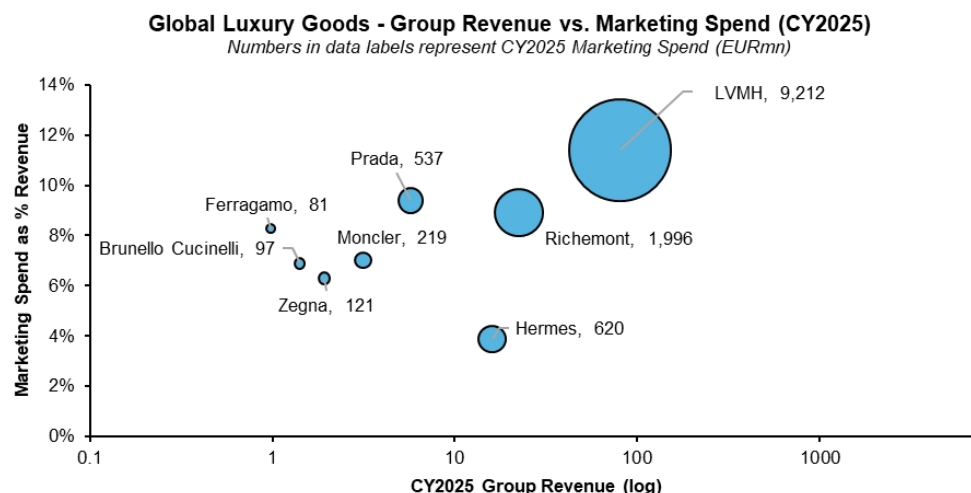
- **Investors would need to benefit from small brands continuing to sustain growth, ideally above sector average.** This is currently possible for high-end specialists like BC and Zegna; debatable for category specialists like Moncler; improbable for most flankers and meteors over the medium to long-term.
- **Alternatively, investors would need to benefit from catching a flanker just before it turns into a meteor.** Which would call for a momentum investment approach with near-perfect timing.

EXHIBIT 16: The mega-brands virtuous cycle underscores how they can accumulate and compound competitive advantages in periods characterised by strong inflows of new middle-class consumers



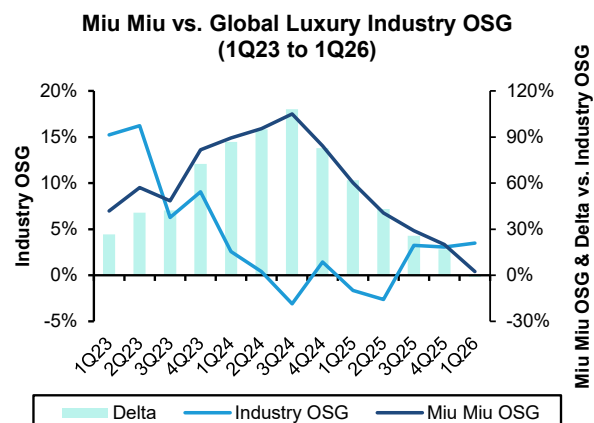
Source: Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 17: However, even in the current environment—arguably more supportive of smaller brands—the scale of resources available to large players remains a significant barrier to competition, making it challenging for smaller brands not only to compete effectively but also to sustain outperformance over time



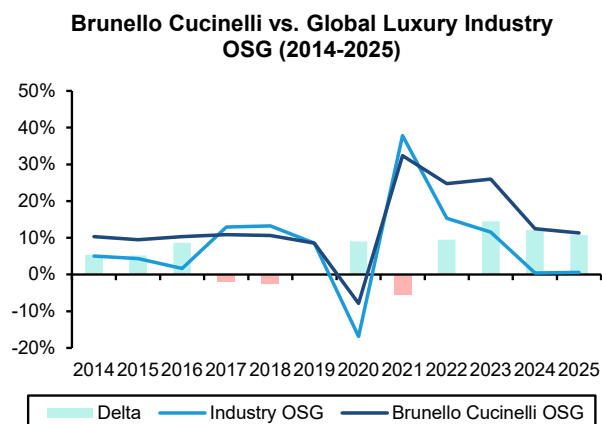
Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 18: Miu Miu, a notable example of a smaller brand that experienced a meteoric rise, also appears to have lost momentum



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

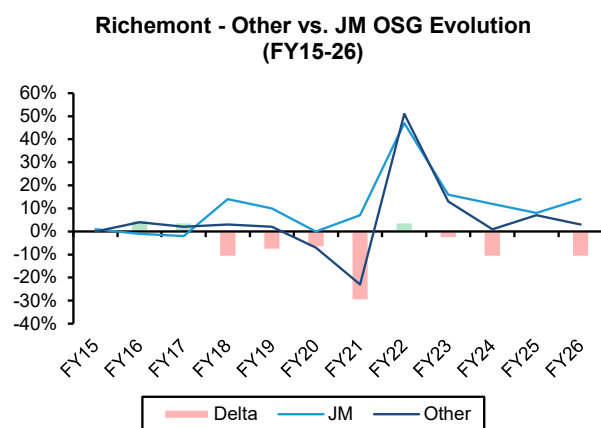
EXHIBIT 19: In contrast, high-end specialists such as Brunello Cucinelli have consistently outperformed the industry, delivering superior performance in 8 of the past 12 years



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

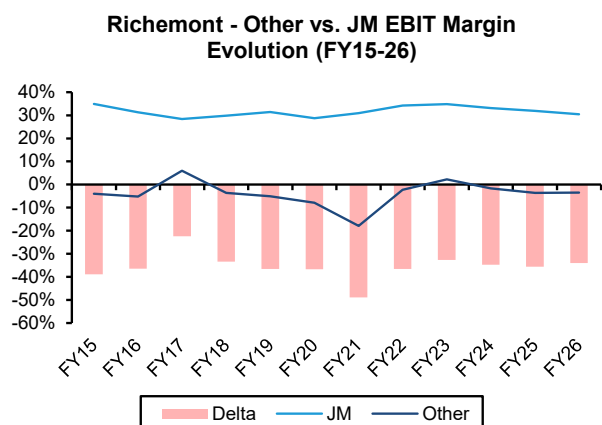
Luxury conglomerates without a mega-brand would have little justification to own flankers within the broader luxury fashion and leather goods market. Richemont stands out in this respect, as owning brands like Chloe, Dunhill, Gianvito Rossi or Serapien seems - at best - only responding to a will to learn (at a cost) about soft luxury. But without any prospect of producing profit performance and capital returns anywhere near those of the hard luxury core business. More simply said: if you don't have a mega-brand, your small brands cannot be flankers, hence they serve very little constructive purpose.

EXHIBIT 20: Richemont's "Other" division—comprising soft luxury brands such as Chloé, Dunhill, Gianvito Rossi, and Serapien—has consistently underperformed JM, which houses the two hard luxury mega-brands, Cartier and VCA



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

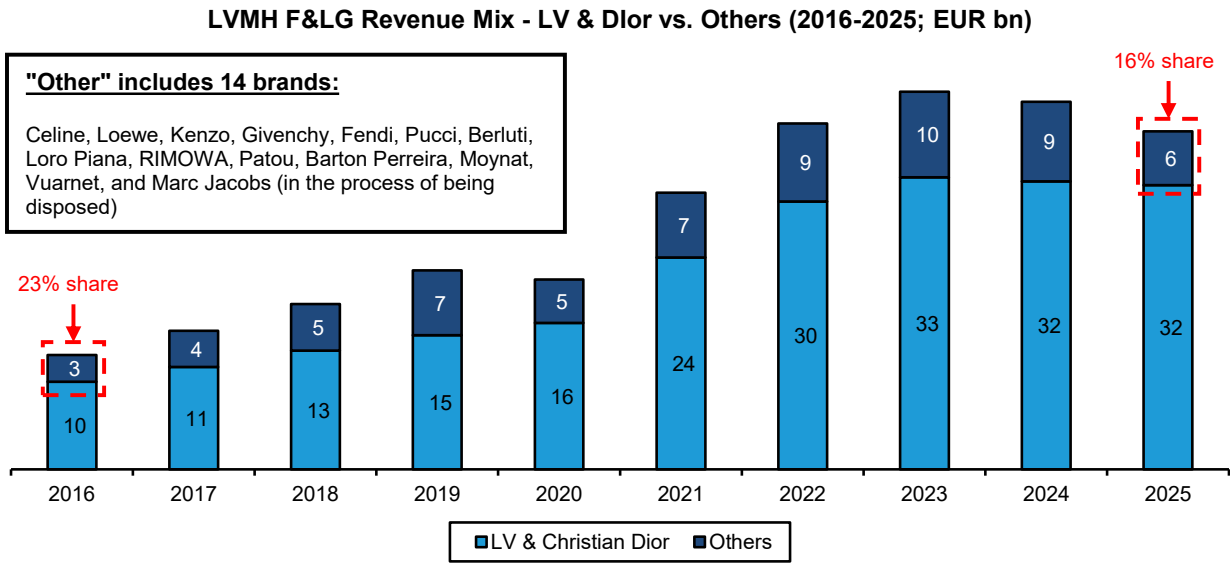
EXHIBIT 21: Over the past decade, the "Other" division has been profitable in only two years, with a persistent and significant margin gap relative to JM



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

Even major luxury conglomerates with deep pockets (courtesy of their mega-brands) benefit from pruning their flankers when markets are tough. The recent examples of Richemont divesting Baume & Mercier and LVMH selling Marc Jacobs are a case in point. Of course, selling loss making businesses is very difficult, which limits Kering's options when dealing with Alexander McQueen at the moment.

EXHIBIT 22: **The smaller non-LV/Dior brands have underperformed the division's overall growth, with many likely operating at a loss today—particularly the 12 brands excluding Loewe and Loro Piana**



Source: Company reports, Bernstein estimates and analysis

DISCLOSURE APPENDIX

I. REQUIRED DISCLOSURES

References to "Bernstein" or the "Firm" in these disclosures relate to the following entities: Bernstein Institutional Services LLC (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein & Co., LLC (pre April 1, 2024), Bernstein Autonomous LLP, BSG France S.A. (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein (Hong Kong) Limited 盛博香港有限公司, Sanford C. Bernstein (Canada) Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein (India) Private Limited (SEBI registration no. INH000006378), Sanford C. Bernstein (Singapore) Private Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein Japan KK (サンフォード・C・バーンスタイン株式会社) and analysts employed by Société Générale Africa Technologies & Services to produce Bernstein research under a Global Services Agreement in place between Bernstein and Société Générale.

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RATINGS DEFINITIONS, BENCHMARKS AND DISTRIBUTION**EQUITY RATINGS DEFINITIONS****Bernstein brand**

The Bernstein brand rates stocks based on forecasts of relative performance for the next 12 months versus the S&P 500 for stocks listed on the U.S. and Canadian exchanges, versus the Bloomberg Europe Developed Markets Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index EUR (EDME) for stocks listed on the European exchanges and emerging markets exchanges outside of the Asia Pacific region, versus the Bloomberg Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index USD (JPL) for stocks listed on the Japanese exchanges, and versus the Bloomberg Asia ex-Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index (ASIA) for stocks listed on the Asian (ex-Japan) exchanges -unless otherwise specified.

The Bernstein brand has three categories of ratings:

- Outperform: Stock will outpace the market index by more than 15 pp
- Market-Perform: Stock will perform in line with the market index to within +/- 15 pp
- Underperform: Stock will trail the performance of the market index by more than 15 pp

Coverage Suspended: Coverage of a company under the Bernstein research brand has been suspended. Ratings and price targets are suspended temporarily, are no longer current, and should therefore not be relied upon.

Not Rated: A rating assigned when the stock cannot be accurately valued, or the performance of the company accurately predicted, at the present time. The covering analyst may continue to publish research reports on the company to update investors on events and developments.

Not Covered (NC) denotes companies that are not under coverage.

Bernstein brand stock ratings are based on a 12-month time horizon.

Autonomous brand – common stocks

The Autonomous brand rates common stocks as indicated below. As our benchmarks we use the Bloomberg Europe 500 Banks And Financial Services Index (BEBANKS) and Bloomberg Europe Dev Mkt Financials Large and Mid Cap Price Ret Index EUR (EDMFI) index for developed European banks and Payments, the Bloomberg Europe 500 Insurance Index (BEINSUR) for European insurers, the S&P 500 and S&P Financials for US banks and Payments coverage, S5LIFE for US Insurance, the S&P Insurance Select Industry (SPSIINS) for US Non-Life Insurers coverage, and the Bloomberg Emerging Markets Financials Large, Mid and Small Cap Price Return Index (EMLSF) for emerging market banks and insurers and Payments. Ratings are stated relative to the sector (not the market).

The Autonomous brand has three categories of common stock ratings:

- Outperform (OP): Stock will outpace the relevant index by more than 10 pp
- Neutral (N): Stock will perform in line with the market index to within +/- 10 pp
- Underperform (UP): Stock will trail the performance of the relevant index by more than 10 pp

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